Uttar Pradesh's IAS strength was upped from 652 to 683. Haryana is seeking to fill a gap of 44 in its sanctioned 226. Under Virbhadra Singh, even Himachal had sought more officers.

**INCOME DISPARITY?**

What, then, is goading Sukhu? Money. In his calculation, the state would save anywhere between Rs 100 crore and double that every year with a leaner force. Behind this turn to frugality is not a 'fiscal crisis' in the usual sense. Himachal is not a poor state. Its per capita income for 2025-26 is estimated at Rs 2.83 lakh, comfortably above the national level of Rs 2.19 lakh. Its economy grew at about 8.3 per cent in real terms against India's 7.4 per cent. Tax revenue, at 5.5 per cent of GSDP, is not far out of line either.



**Takeaways**

- **Sukhu wants to prune state's IAS strength. Even salaries of CM, ministers, MLAs held up**
- **Big bone of contention: the withdrawal of Revenue Deficit Grants. Rs 8k cr. loss, says CM**
- **Critics cite poor revenue collection, 22% cut in capital outlay, call it empty rhetoric**

Yet, the 2026-27 budget was the first in the state's history smaller than the one before it, falling to Rs 54,928 crore from Rs 58,514 crore. It has to pay out salaries, pensions and interest amounting to Rs 35,641 crore, a jaw-dropping 88 per cent of estimated revenue receipts, up from 80 per cent two fiscals ago. The average Indian state budgets about 50-55 per cent. The payout for the IAS cadre would have been a little over one per cent of Sukhu's wage bill, but take that as a sign of nervousness rather than efficiency.

Its cause was revealed back on February 1, when the 16th Finance Commission recommended that no state would be given revenue deficit grants, arguing that they create an adverse incentive. These grants were designed as a gap-filling mechanism to ensure financially stressed states could roll out essential services without falling into debt. States like Himachal, Punjab, Kerala and several in the Northeast have historically been major beneficiaries. Himachal got Rs 37,199 crore over five years under the previous commission, tapering down from Rs 10,249 crore in 2021-22 to Rs 3,257 crore in 2025-26. That tap is being turned off. Sukhu pegs the annual loss at Rs 8,105 crore. The state is examining legal options.

His grievances, in fact, run longer. Sukhu says discontinued GST compensation adds up to Rs 2,500-3,000 crore a year; Rs 9,042 crore is still due under disaster relief for the 2023 monsoon; Rs 9,200 crore of pension deductions are held by the Centre; and the state copped a penalty cut of Rs 2,000 crore to its borrowing limit for restoring the Old Pension Scheme.

The arguments run like a traffic jam on the Manali highway. Sukhu alleges central bias for being an Opposition state. Sceptics talk of inefficiency, citing a pile-up of unrealised land revenue, and look askance at a capital outlay down 22 per cent from last fiscal. Back in Shimla? Even salaries for the CM, his ministers, MLAs and senior officials stand deferred for six months. A landslide has hit that highway. ■

▶ MAHARASHTRA

# Faith and Fear at the Altar

**Churches in Mumbai begin to ask worshippers, old and new, to sign a consent form attesting to free choice**

*By* **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

**WITH MAHARASHTRA NOW THE 13TH** state to enact an anti-conversion law, churches here have begun seeking consent forms from worshippers testifying that they are visiting the church voluntarily, sans any pressure or inducement. The Maharashtra Freedom of Religion Act, 2026, penalises violations by individuals, organisations and institutions with up to 10 years in jail and a fine of up to Rs 7 lakh. The law has sparked off fears about its misuse



**PAPER TRAIL** Consent forms distributed to churchgoers during a Sunday service, Virar